

Development at an “almost complete standstill”?

Testing the Malta Developers Association’s 2021 warning about construction-waste dumping

THE CLAIM UNDER REVIEW

“...development will come to an ‘almost complete standstill.’”

Malta Developers Association, statement of 2 June 2021, as reported by MaltaToday.

The conditional framing is the outlet’s; only the words in quotation marks are the Association’s.

VERDICT: NOT SUBSTANTIATED

Real bottleneck; the scale of the warning is unshown

Version 1.0 · 5 October 2026

Status: draft, pending right of reply

Prepared from public sources and Eurostat data.

Repository: github.com/leandergrech/Mizien

MIŻIEN · AN INDEPENDENT FACT-CHECKING PROJECT

Contest a verdict, with evidence: github.com/leandergrech/Mizien/issues

TL;DR

On 2 June 2021 the Malta Developers Association (MDA) warned that unless an “imminent and enduring” solution was found to the dumping of construction waste, development would come to an “**almost complete standstill**”. We checked the warning against Eurostat’s construction output and waste data.

- 1 Disposal space was a real problem.** Road works were halted in 2020 for lack of dumping space, government fixed a €12 a tonne gate fee, and in June 2021 contractors said that fee strained their tenders (MaltaToday, BusinessToday).
- 2 No standstill appears in the data.** Malta’s construction output (volume) rose 5.8% in 2021 and 5.5% in 2022, to 162.5 (2015 = 100). It is the latest year Eurostat publishes for Malta.
- 3 But the warning was conditional, and the condition changed.** Government announced a construction and demolition waste strategy of 15 measures in October 2021. We cannot say what would have happened with no solution, so the data neither confirm nor refute the warning.
- 4 Verdict: not substantiated (moderate confidence).** The MDA published no analysis behind “almost complete standstill”, and none exists in the sources we could read. The concern is real; the degree is unshown.

THIS CLAIM

SUPPORTED

LARGELY
SUPPORTED

NOT
SUBSTANTIATED

MISLEADING

CONTRADICTED

+5.8%

Construction output volume,
2021 (+5.5% in 2022)

2.1 Mt

Waste from construction, 2022
(3.0 Mt in 2020)

78%

Construction’s share of all waste
generated in Malta, 2022

€12/t

Fixed fee for construction waste
at Wied Incita since 2020

WHAT WOULD MOVE THE VERDICT UP

Evidence of what stalled after June 2021 because of disposal limits (stopped projects, tenders, quarry capacity), or the MDA’s own analysis behind its warning.

WHAT WOULD MOVE IT DOWN

Evidence that output kept growing through the period for reasons unrelated to disposal, or an MDA analysis that showed the warning was a forecast with a method.

IN THIS REPORT

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2 Method

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7 Limitations

1 The claim and what we could verify

MaltaToday reported the Association’s statement on 2 June 2021 [1]. Only the words inside quotation marks are the Association’s own in that report: the “almost complete standstill” warning, its remark that there “has been a patchwork of attempted solutions along the years”, and its description of the situation as “untenable” (attributed to director-general Deborah Schembri). The conditional framing (“unless a solution is found”) is the outlet’s paraphrase of the statement. We could not reach the Association’s own text; the page was read from an Internet Archive copy, because the live site returns 403. BusinessToday (17 June 2021) repeats the warning and quotes MDA president Sandro Chetcuti on the cost of dumping [2].

Source	What it says	Our access	Status
MaltaToday , 2 Jun 2021 [1]	MDA warns “unless an imminent and enduring solution” is found, development will come to an “almost complete standstill”; “intense discussions” with government under way.	Read, Internet Archive copy.	The claim (outlet’s report of the statement)
BusinessToday , 17 Jun 2021 [2]	Contractors’ tenders assumed €5–8 a tonne; quarry owners charge €12; MDA proposes land for recycling and exporting waste.	Read, Internet Archive copy.	Context
MaltaToday , 9 Oct 2021 [3]	Environment Minister announces a construction and demolition waste strategy of 15 measures in four areas.	Read, Internet Archive copy.	Context
Eurostat [4–6]	Construction output (volume); waste generated and treated, Malta.	Downloaded 5 Oct 2026.	Primary data

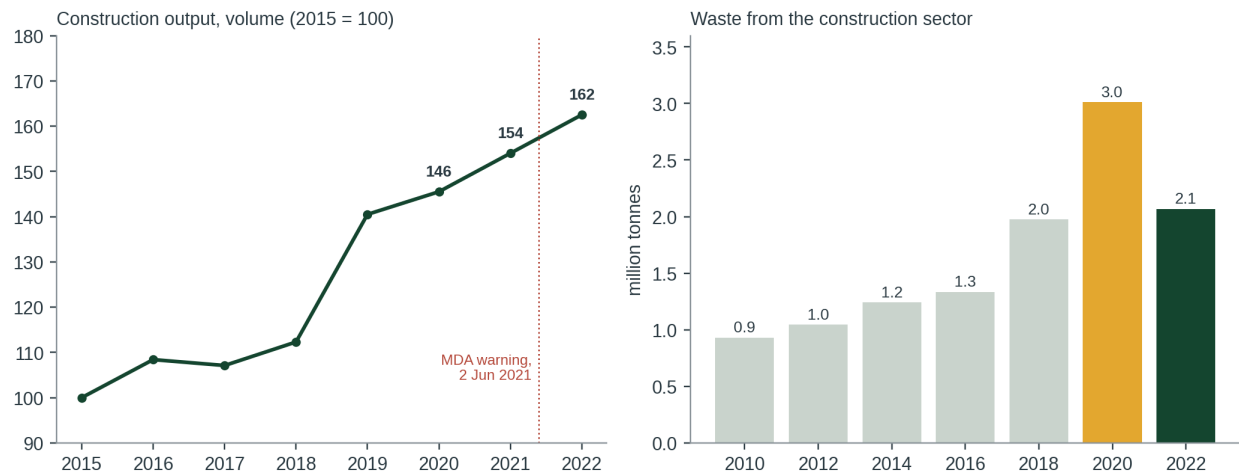
2 Method

Question. Is the warning that development would almost completely stop, absent a solution to construction-waste dumping, supported?

Evidence. We located the statement and its context, then downloaded three Eurostat series for Malta (*data/cc-063/*): production in construction (*sts_copr_a*, volume index), waste generated by the construction sector (*env_wasgen*) and treatment of mineral construction and demolition waste (*env_wastrt*). Calculations are in *tools/cc-063-report/calc.py* with outputs in *data/cc-063/checks.csv*.

Limits of the test. A warning of the form “unless X, then Y” can only be tested directly if X did not happen. Here, government acted (a fee in 2020, a strategy in October 2021), so the data can show whether the feared outcome occurred, not whether it would have without action. **Grades:** Eurostat statistics are grade C; the MDA statement is an assertion (D). **Verdicts** follow Appendix A.

3 What the data show



Sources: Eurostat sts_copr_a (updated 2 Oct 2026; 2022 provisional; no later year published for Malta) and env_wasgen (NACE F, all waste; biennial), retrieved 5 Oct 2026.

Figure 1. Left: Malta's construction output, volume index (2015 = 100). Right: waste from the construction sector, all waste, millions of tonnes (biennial).

Construction output rose from 145.5 in 2020 to 154.0 in 2021 (+5.8%) and 162.5 in 2022 (+5.5%, provisional), 11.7% above 2020. Eurostat has no later year for Malta, so the data say nothing about 2023 onwards. Waste from the construction sector was 3.0 million tonnes in 2020 and 2.1 million in 2022 (–31%), but 4.7% above 2018. It is 78% of all waste generated in Malta in 2022 (84% in 2020). Of the mineral construction and demolition waste treated in 2022, 67% was recycled and 33% used for backfilling, with landfill negligible; Eurostat classes backfilling as recovery, so this does not show how much went to quarries for disposal.

4 Where the evidence points different ways

Did the disposal bottleneck threaten to stop development?

UNSETTLED

FOR

In 2020 Infrastructure Malta ordered road works to stop for lack of dumping space and the high price asked by the few quarries accepting waste; government then imposed a €12 a tonne fee [1]. In June 2021 contractors said road works had again largely halted over costs [2]. Construction waste has grown with the pace of development [3].

AGAINST

Output kept growing in 2021 and 2022. The Environment Minister said in 2020 that there was ample quarry space, but not all quarries accepted debris [1]. A strategy followed in October 2021 [3]. We found no published data on the number of stalled projects.

WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE

A real bottleneck existed and affected road works. An “almost complete standstill” of development is a far stronger statement; it has no published analysis and did not show in national output through 2022.

5 Testing the claim

Sub-claim	Said by	What the evidence shows	Rating
A. Dumping of construction waste had no enduring solution in June 2021	MDA [1]	Road works halted in 2020 and strain reported again in 2021; the MDA calls past fixes a “patchwork”.	SUPPORTED
B. Without one, development would come to an almost complete standstill	MDA [1]	No analysis published. Output grew 5.8% (2021) and 5.5% (2022), but government acted, so the counterfactual is untestable.	NOT SUBSTANTIATED

6 Verdict and requests for evidence

VERDICT

NOT SUBSTANTIATED

The disposal problem was real, but “almost complete standstill” has no published basis and did not appear in national output. Confidence: moderate.

Why. Our scale rates a claim *Not substantiated* when it is stated more strongly than the evidence available allows. The shortage of disposal capacity is documented; the degree of harm forecast is not. Confidence is moderate because output data stop at 2022 and say little about specific projects.

What this verdict does not say. It does not say the developers were wrong to raise the problem, or that nothing stalled: road works did. It treats a negotiating warning as the kind of statement it is, and asks what evidence backs its strength. A fuller sentence would read: “*Without more disposal capacity, construction, and road works in particular, faces delays and higher costs.*”

Evidence we are asking for

- ☐ From the MDA: the analysis or member survey behind “almost complete standstill”.
- ☐ From ERA and the Planning Authority: quarry intake and remaining capacity by year since 2020.
- ☐ From Infrastructure Malta: projects suspended for lack of dumping space in 2020–21.

RIGHT OF REPLY

Pending. Under the maintainer’s rule of 5 October 2026 a reply is sought for *Not substantiated* verdicts. The maintainer will contact the MDA; this report will be updated with any response.

7 Limitations

- We did not reach the MDA’s own statement; wording is from MaltaToday’s report, read from an Internet Archive copy.
- Eurostat output data end in 2022 (provisional) and waste data in 2022; later years are untested.
- Eurostat’s waste data count backfilling as recovery, so they do not separate quarry disposal from recycling.
- National output could hide local stoppages; we have no project-level data.

References

- [1] Calleja, L. (2 Jun 2021). Developers again call for enduring solution to dumping of construction waste. MaltaToday. https://www.maltatoday.com.mt/news/national/110023/developers_again_call_for_enduring_solution_to_dumping_of_construction_waste
- [2] Cocks, P. (17 Jun 2021). Crippling construction waste dumping costs behind road works standstill, MDA says. BusinessToday. https://www.businesstoday.com.mt/business/business/1503/crippling_construction_waste_dumping_costs_behind_road_works_standstill_mda_says
- [3] Vella, L. (9 Oct 2021). Construction drive produced unprecedented levels of construction waste, Farrugia says. MaltaToday. https://www.maltatoday.com.mt/news/national/112566/construction_drive_produced_unprecedented_levels_of_construction_waste_farrugia_says
- [4] Eurostat. Production in construction, annual data (sts_copr_a), updated 2 Oct 2026, retrieved 5 Oct 2026. https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/databrowser/view/sts_copr_a/default/table
- [5] Eurostat. Generation of waste by waste category, hazardousness and NACE Rev. 2 activity (env_wasgen), updated Sep 2025. https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/databrowser/view/env_wasgen/default/table
- [6] Eurostat. Treatment of waste by waste category, hazardousness and waste management operations (env_wastrt), updated Sep 2025. https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/databrowser/view/env_wastrt/default/table
- [7] Miżien. Calculation script and outputs: tools/cc-063-report/calc.py; data/cc-063/.

Appendix A: series standards and verdict scale

Every investigation in this series follows the same rules so that verdicts are comparable and challengeable.

Verdict	Meaning
SUPPORTED	Evidence consistently backs the claim as stated.
LARGELY SUPPORTED	Backed by the evidence, with minor caveats that do not change the substance.
NOT SUBSTANTIATED	Stated more strongly than the evidence offered or available allows. May be true in some conditions but has not been shown.
MISLEADING	Omits material facts so that the overall impression is inaccurate, even if individual statements are defensible.
CONTRADICTED	The available evidence points against the claim.

Confidence

High: multiple independent lines of evidence agree. **Moderate:** evidence is relevant but incomplete or indirect. **Low:** evidence is thin, second-hand or conflicting.

Evidence grades

A experiment · B observational study with a control or gradient · C review, guidance or official statistics · D assertion or anecdote. ♦ marks a source known only second-hand.

Standards

- **Quote the speaker, not the headline**, with outlet and date, and link the original where possible.
- **Separate the claim from the evidence offered for it**, and say who made which statement.
- **Grade the evidence** and show differing views side by side where the evidence is unsettled.
- **State what we could not access or verify**, and what would change the verdict either way.
- **Ask for the missing evidence** in specific, answerable requests.
- **Offer a right of reply** where a check finds a claim Not substantiated, Misleading or Contradicted (or a pledge Not measurable, Off track or Missed), before wider circulation, and append responses.
- **Correct errors openly** with a version number and change log.
- **Whistle-blow only on evidence:** a verdict of *Misleading* or *Contradicted* requires documents or data that can be shown, not inference.
- **Check every side.** Government, opposition, NGOs and developers are held to the same standard.

Appendix B: revision log

Version	Date	Change
1.0	5 Oct 2026	First issue. Verdict Not substantiated (moderate confidence); pending right of reply.